



WELCOME

Lecture: 03

Ancient Bengal

Course Title: History of the Emergence of Bangladesh

Course Code: BDS 1201

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Ancient Bengal includes modern-day Bangladesh and the Indian states of West Bengal, Tripura and Assam's Karimganj district, located in the eastern part of the Indian subcontinent, at the apex of the Bay of Bengal and dominated by the fertile Ganges delta.

➤ **Gangaridai**

➤ Alexander the Great and Gangaridai

8th to 12th Century:

- Different kinds of indigenous people were found in India subcontinent
- Maurya and Gupta Empire
- Bangla was the capital of various regions in different times
- Gaur was the capital of Pala and Sena dynasty
- Bangla language, literature, art, music all were developed

13th to 17th Century:

- Muslim Sultanate, Baro-Bhuyans, Hindu Rajas were the leaders
- Isa Khan leads the Baro-Bhuyans
- The region was known as a major trading nation in the world
- Introduction of the taka as monetary currency
- Under the Mughals, Bengal Subah rose to global prominence in industries such as textile manufacturing and shipbuilding & 50% GDP
- The gradual decline of the Mughal Empire led to quasi-independent states under the Nawabs of Bengal, subsequent to the Maratha invasions of Bengal, and finally the conquest by the British East India Company.

18th Century

- The East India Company
- Battle of Plassey in 1757 & Battle of Buxar in 1764
- Industrial Revolution
- Deindustrialization of the Bengali textile industry

1947

West Bengal—a state of India & East Bengal—Pakistan

1971

Later became the independent nation of Bangladesh

Between 600 BC - 400 BC, Bengal was politically divided into several Janapads.

Pundra:

- Most ancient kingdom
- Named after prince Pundram, son of the king Bali
- Comprised of the present Bogra, Rangpur, Rajshahi and Dinajpur districts
- Capital- Pundranagar later Pundra Vardhana

Gaur

- Situated in the northern part of East Bengal in 6th century
- was first referred to in the book of Panini
- Sasanka was the king of Gaur
- Karnasuborna the present district of Murshidabad was the capital

Banga

- very ancient Janapada
- neighbor of Janapadas Magodha and Kalinga
- In Mahabharata that Bengal was a neighboring country of Pundra
- two parts of Banga-
 - i. Vikrampura- present Munshiganj
 - ii. Navya- low lying lands of Faridpur, Bakerganj, Ptuaakhali
- Called powerful region “Banga Raj”. Soldiers took part in many battles

Barendra

- Known as Barendri or Barendrabhumi, janapad of North Bengal
- Included Bogra, Dinajpur, Rajshahi and Pabna

Samatata

- Neighboring janapad of Banga in the East and South of Bengal
- Chinese traveller Hiuen Sung travelled here
- Previous name of Comilla
- Comprised of Comilla and Nowakhali
- The name of capital- Bara Kamta (in 17th century)

Harikela

- Not a separate janapad, rather included in Banga janapad
- Sylhet

Chandradeep

- another tinier Janapada in ancient Bengal
- Barisal
- situated in the place between the Baleshwar and the Meghna

Besides, in greater ancient Bengal there were some other Janapadas named Dandobhukti, North Rahr (the western part of present Murshidabad region, whole Birbhum region and Katoa Sub-division of the Budwan region), South Rahr (the southern part of present Budwan, many parts of Hoogly and Howrah region), Bangla (generally Sundarban forests of Khulna, Patuakhali and Barisal) etc.

Thus different parts of ancient Bengal were known by different names from the ancient time till the sixth-seventh century. Basically, it was an economic and geographical division.

At the start of the seventh century Sasanka after becoming the king of Gaur organized the total area from Murshidabad to Utkol (North orissa). After that Bengal used to be known by the name of three Janapada. These were Pundravardhana, Banga and Gaur. The existence of the left others were lost in them.

We can get a fair conception of geographical shape, demarcation, political characteristics of the then Bengal from the Janapadas of ancient Bengal. Then there was no political unity in ancient Bengal. The powerful rulers would gain ruling power of more than one Janapada through executing their domination. Thus these Janapadas played roles as the first territorial unit or administrative unit in ancient Bengal.

THANK
YOU!
